

UNIVERSITY PROGRAM DOSSIER · THE ADMISSION BOOK

# University of Cambridge — Psychological and Behavioural Sciences (BA)

Program Dossier · The Admission Book · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 16, 2026

Cambridge's **Psychological and Behavioural Sciences** tripos is the empirical route into this book's central question — study the mind scientifically, borrow papers from philosophy, politics and computational biology, and finish with a **7,000-word Part II dissertation** that can carry a human-versus-machine-cognition project. Uniquely among the strong-fit courses at either ancient university, **PBS requires no pre-registered admissions test** — the assessment happens at interview, set by the college. The governing facts: an applicant may apply to **Cambridge or Oxford, not both**; UCAS closes **October 15, 2026** with Cambridge's own form and transcript due **October 22**; the **US success rate was 5.5%** in the 2025 cycle; and there are **no need-based grants for international undergraduates** — though the 3-year degree keeps total cost well under a 4-year US private. One pricing trap: PBS is billed as a science (£44,214 in 2026/27) while the HSPS/Law alternates cost £29,052.

## 1. The university at a glance

| Fact                        | Detail                                                                                                                      | Source                                     |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Location / type             | Cambridge, England; collegiate public research university; 31 colleges; supervision teaching                                | <a href="#">How the University works</a>   |
| Identity line               | <i>Hinc lucem et pocula sacra</i> — “From here, light and sacred draughts”                                                  | <a href="#">Coat of arms</a>               |
| Overall admit rate          | <b>16.3%</b> (2025 cycle: 22,513 applied, 3,669 admitted)                                                                   | <a href="#">2025 statistics PDF</a>        |
| <b>US applicant success</b> | <b>5.5%</b> (597 applications, 33 admitted, 2025 cycle)                                                                     | Same PDF                                   |
| Course admit rate           | <b>PBS: 12.9%</b> (611 applied, 79 admitted; ~8 applications/place)                                                         | Same PDF · <a href="#">PBS course page</a> |
| US academic benchmark       | <b>Five AP 5s</b> + SAT ≥1460 (EBRW ≥730) or ACT ≥32 for arts-side courses                                                  | <a href="#">Accepted qualifications</a>    |
| Application                 | <b>UCAS Oct 15, 2026, 6pm UK + My Cambridge Application Oct 22</b> (£60; transcript upload) · decisions <b>Jan 27, 2027</b> | <a href="#">Dates &amp; deadlines</a>      |
| Admissions test             | <b>None to pre-register for PBS</b> — college-set assessment at interview                                                   | <a href="#">Admissions tests</a>           |
| Fees (overseas, 2026/27)    | <b>PBS £44,214</b> + college fee ~£11.5–15k + living ~£12k · 3-year degree                                                  | <a href="#">International fees</a>         |

## 2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

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Cambridge pairs a university-wide tripos (the course and its examinations) with a college (home, funding, and the **supervision** — small-group teaching it calls “one of the best teaching models in the world”). Admissions culture is subject-first and says so plainly: extracurricular activities “won’t be taken into consideration,” and non-academic material should fill no more than ~20% of any statement section. What counts is **super-curricular** depth — reading, projects and reflection beyond any syllabus — and an interview that works like a live supervision on unseen material.

The college layer softens the odds in one useful way: the **winter pool** re-homes roughly a thousand strong applicants each January to colleges with space, so choosing a competitive college is not fatal. The strategic direction helps too — the Vice-Chancellor’s 2025 address committed West Cambridge to becoming Europe’s leading hub for **AI, quantum and climate research**.

## 3. The program — Psychological and Behavioural Sciences

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- **Part IA (Year 1).** Three compulsory papers — *Introduction to Experimental Psychology: From Brain to Cognition*, *Social Psychology and Individual Differences*, *From Subjective Questions to Objective Science* — plus **one paper borrowed from another tripos**: options span philosophy, politics, sociology, evolution and mathematical biology.
- **Part IB (Year 2).** Compulsory *Behavioural and Cognitive Neuroscience* and *Developmental Psychology*, plus two options including **philosophy of science** and **computational biology**.
- **Part II (Year 3).** Three papers plus a **7,000-word research dissertation** on a self-chosen topic — the natural vehicle for a project on human versus machine judgment.
- No psychology background is required; the science expectation is covered by AP-level mathematics and computer science.

The AI thread is assembled rather than badged — borrowed papers, the dissertation, and Cambridge’s ecosystem: the **Leverhulme Centre for the Future of Intelligence** (philosophers, cognitive scientists and ML researchers on AI’s nature, ethics and impact; public events open to all) and the new **Bennett School of Public Policy** (a department since 2025, launching an **MPhil in Digital Policy** in October 2026 — a natural master’s step after this BA).

**Alternates within Cambridge.** *HSPS* — the institutions spine (politics, international relations, sociology; Part II in Politics & IR) with a psychology borrow, at the £29k fee tier. *Law BA* — the direct route: Part II offers a full **Intellectual Property** paper and a **Personal Data Protection Law** half-paper around the CIPIL centre. *Computer Science* — honestly flagged as the wrong shape here: theory-first, 97% of entrants with Further Maths, 14 applications per place. Switching tripos after Part I (e.g., PBS → Law) is an established, college-governed pattern — possible, never guaranteed.

## 4. How the pieces fit together

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The profile this book is built around treats cognition as the scientific core, computation as the toolkit, and institutions as the destination. PBS runs that exact sequence: empirical method first, computational and philosophical borrowings second, and a dissertation that can fuse them — with the Leverhulme Centre supplying the AI-governance conversation and the Bennett School a visible graduate pathway. What PBS does not supply is a coding curriculum; the technical identity is maintained through project work rather than coursework, which is honest to state and consistent with a not-engineering-maximal preference.

## 5. An illustrative path

| Year      | Core                                  | Borrowed / options                                          | Outside the degree                                          |
|-----------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1<br>(IA) | Brain to Cognition; scientific method | Philosophy or politics paper                                | Instrumental Awards audition (early Oct); college orchestra |
| 2<br>(IB) | Cognitive neuroscience; developmental | Philosophy of science or computational biology              | Leverhulme CFI public events                                |
| 3 (II)    | Three papers                          | <b>7,000-word dissertation</b> (human vs. machine judgment) | Bennett School MPhil / US law-school applications           |

## 6. Beyond the classroom — the violin at Cambridge

Cambridge is arguably the best Oxbridge home for a serious non-degree violinist. The **Instrumental Awards Scheme** exists precisely for musicians reading other subjects: Grade VIII-Distinction-plus standard, a year-long chamber-ensemble placement with **six professional coaching sessions**, showcase concerts, a small award and subsidized lessons — applications typically open mid-August with solo auditions in early October of the first term. The **Centre for Music Performance** runs the Cambridge University Orchestra and sibling ensembles (auditioned, any subject), and college music provision is a real differentiator — Fitzwilliam’s 240-seat auditorium, four practice rooms and string scholarships; St John’s, Caius, Queens’ and Robinson all maintain strong schemes. Screen colleges for music before choosing one on the UCAS form.

## 7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

- **One Oxbridge slot.** Cambridge’s 2027-entry pages state it directly: an applicant cannot apply to Cambridge and Oxford in the same year. This dossier and the Oxford dossier are mutually exclusive paths.
- **The odds for Americans.** 5.5% success in the 2025 cycle. Five AP 5s and SAT 1460+ is the published *floor*, not a predictor.
- **The pricing trap.** PBS is billed as a science: **£44,214** (2026/27) versus **£29,052** for HSPS/Law/Economics — ~£45k more over three years. 2027-entry fees publish by **October 1, 2026**, *after* the course decision must effectively be made.
- **No need-based grants for internationals.** The Cambridge Bursary is home-status only; proof of funding is collected in My Cambridge Application. US federal loans work (Direct Loan program); Cambridge Trust awards are competitive upside, not a plan. The 3-year structure is the real built-in discount.
- **Transcript logistics.** A registrar letter covering the last two years must be uploaded by **October 22, 2026** — US registrars are slow in September; request it in the first week.
- **Written work.** Some colleges ask PBS applicants for one or two marked essays (Robinson: one; Magdalene, Murray Edwards, Pembroke, St Edmund’s: two) — keep graded humanities work ready.

## 8. Applying — logistics for Fall 2027

| Step             | Date (2027 entry)              | Detail                                                                           |
|------------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UCAS application | <b>by Oct 15, 2026, 6pm UK</b> | One college or open application; academic reference; cannot also apply to Oxford |

| Step                     | Date (2027 entry)              | Detail                                                                              |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| My Cambridge Application | <b>by Oct 22, 2026, 6pm UK</b> | £60 fee; <b>transcript upload</b> ; optional 1,200-character Cambridge statement    |
| Personal statement       | with UCAS                      | 3-question format, 4,000 characters; keep non-academic content ≤20%                 |
| Admissions test          | none to pre-register           | College-set assessment at/around interview                                          |
| Written work             | if college requests            | 1–2 marked essays, college-dependent                                                |
| Interviews               | <b>Dec 7–18, 2026</b>          | Online for internationals; ~two-thirds of PBS applicants interviewed, usually twice |
| Decision                 | <b>Jan 27, 2027</b>            | Winter pool runs mid-late January; conditional offers possible on May 2027 APs      |

## 9. Sources

Cambridge 2025-cycle admissions statistics PDF · PBS course page and tripos site · HSPS, Law, Economics, Computer Science course pages · accepted-qualifications and international entry-requirements pages · application dates, My Cambridge Application, transcript, personal-statement and admissions-tests pages · interviews and winter-pool pages · international fees page and 2026-27 college-fees PDF · living-costs page · Cambridge Bursary, Cambridge Trust and US-loans pages · Leverhulme Centre for the Future of Intelligence · Bennett School of Public Policy · CIPIL · Centre for Music Performance and Instrumental Awards Scheme · Fitzwilliam College music pages. All retrieved August 16, 2026; re-verify time-sensitive dates on official pages — 2027-entry fees publish by October 1, 2026.